

GANTAR SANSTHA Ahmedabad

LESSONS OF LIFE

Though child labour is banned in the country, 50 per cent of primary school students are forced to drop out of school and work as daily labourers. Gantar, a social organisation committed to the upliftment of the rural poor in Surendranagar district in Gujarat, helps the poorest of the poor school dropouts study further through its Bhandtarshala programme. Founded by Sukhdev Patel, 52, this programme also offers courses like cooking, livestock care and management, and organic farming, so that once its students are out of the school, they can go on



SHAILESH RAVAL

STUDENTS GETTING VOCATIONAL TRAINING

to earn a decent living for themselves. Five teachers map the students' minds for their receptivity in subjects like mathematics, science and social sciences for about a month and then grade them. Ever since its inception in 2004, Gantar has so far schooled over 50 underprivileged children. *by Uday Mahurkar*

This model has a success rate of **80 per cent** in educating rural children.

Imagine a school which has no benches and where the teacher does not need a blackboard. This fancy is a reality in Tamil Nadu where government primary schools have adopted the Activity Based Learning (ABL) to educate children. It was in 1994 that

Vellore district collector M.P. Vijayakumar set up a school for children who had been bonded labourers and introduced new methods to make learning enjoyable. Taking the cue, the state government implemented ABL in the primary classes of all government schools. Under ABL, lessons begin with illustrated cards and short words that are easy to write. Students are divided according to their learning levels, not the class they are studying in. "Under ABL, there is less of teaching and more of learning," says Thangam Thennarasu, minister for school education. The education department has now come up with another strategy called the Active Learning Method, for Class VI to VIII in 120 government schools across 12 districts. Here's a lesson well learnt.

by Banumathi Krishnaswamy

28,000 government-run primary schools are using the ABL technique.



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